

Challenge: Where are the robots?

Category: Web Exploitation

Description: The challenge asked to "find the robots" on a given website, hinting at a hidden or restricted resource.

Approach: I recognized "robots" as a reference to robots.txt, a standard file, websites use to tell search engine crawlers which pages should or shouldn't be indexed. I navigated directly to <http://xebec.cylabacademy.net:16188/robots.txt>, which listed a disallowed path. Visiting that path directly in the browser revealed the flag.

Difficulty Faced: I wasn't initially aware that robots.txt was a standard web convention worth checking — this isn't something derivable through logic alone, it's a known convention in web reconnaissance. Once pointed toward it, the rest of the solve was straightforward.

Tools used: Web browser

Flag: academy{ca1cu1at1ng_Mach1n3s_5ed99}

What I learned: robots.txt is a standard file used to control search engine crawling behavior, but it can inadvertently reveal paths meant to stay hidden from public indexing, since the file itself is publicly accessible even though its *purpose* is to restrict crawler visibility. This is a genuinely common first step in real-world web reconnaissance — checking standard, well-known file locations before attempting anything more complex.